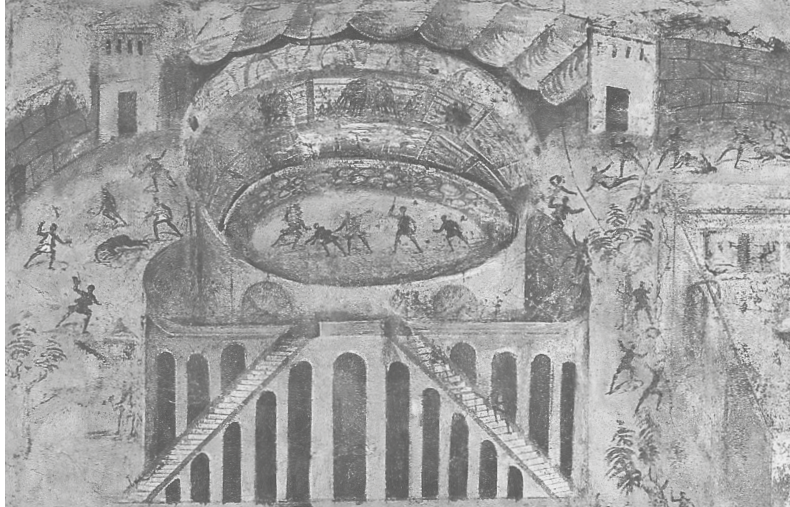




A WALL PAINTING OF A RIOT IN 59 CE AT POMPEII'S ARENA. THE SUN BLIND, OR CANOPY, IS AT THE TOP OF THE PICTURE.

Pictures in paint

The Romans were expert craftworkers. They excelled in decorating the walls, floors, and ceilings of their public and private buildings with pictures. Paintings were often designed to suit the function of the room in which they appeared. For example, pictures of fish and river scenes appeared in the baths, and the dining rooms of houses featured hunting images, dead animals, and banquets.

Artists painted rooms with panels and bands of bright color, particularly red. Some walls were decorated with landscape scenes, flowers, or figures from Greek and Roman mythology. To our eyes, these brightly colored rooms can

seem "over the top," but to the Romans, they were the height of fashion and good taste.

We're lucky that any of these fragile paintings have survived at all, but many have. Some are documentary images, recording scenes from real life, just as newspaper photographs do today. An instance of this can be seen in a wall painting from Pompeii, a small town south of Rome, where an unknown artist painted a riot scene. The riot happened in 59 CE, in and

WEIRD WORLD

ROMAN ACTORS WERE SKILLED AT MAKING SOUND EFFECTS.

FOR EXAMPLE, THE SOUND OF THUNDER WAS MADE BY ROLLING BRONZE BALLS DOWN A METAL TUBE SO THAT THEY CRASHED ONTO A SHEET OF TIN.